Big Small World - Final Journal

Assessment 2

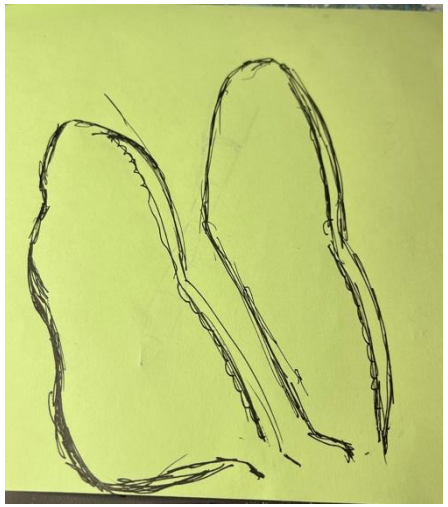
Kira Zakirov

A00153068

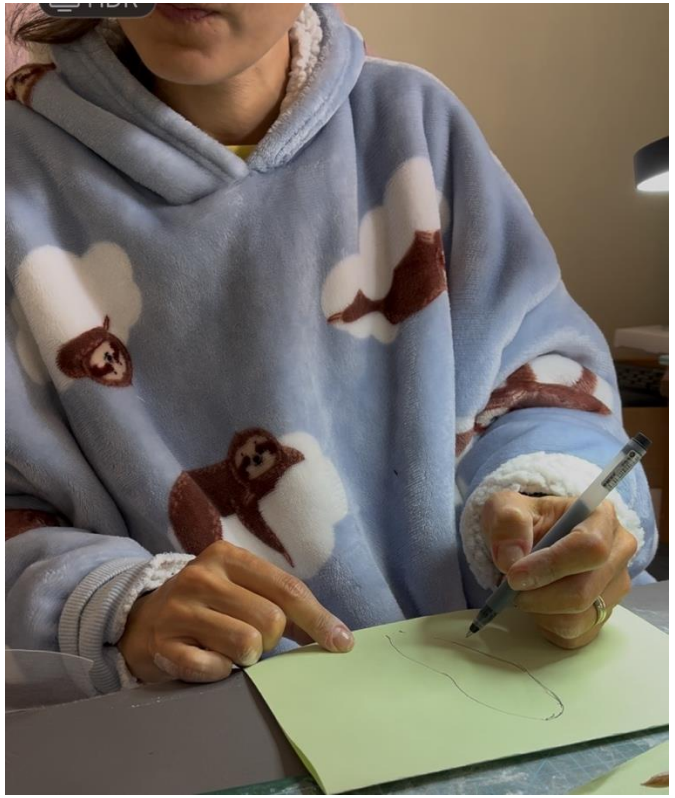
Design Studio 1 - (DSO102)

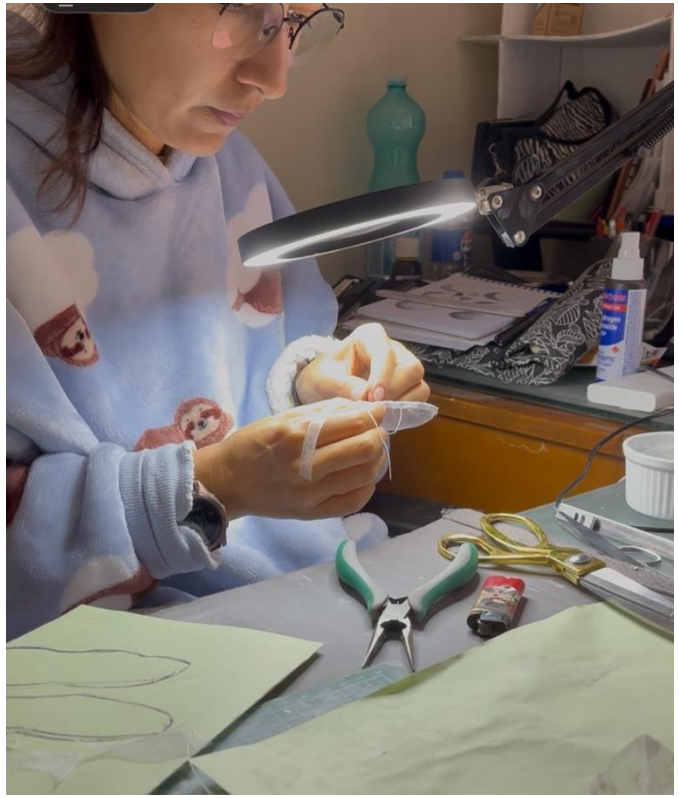
Pocess journal

Head

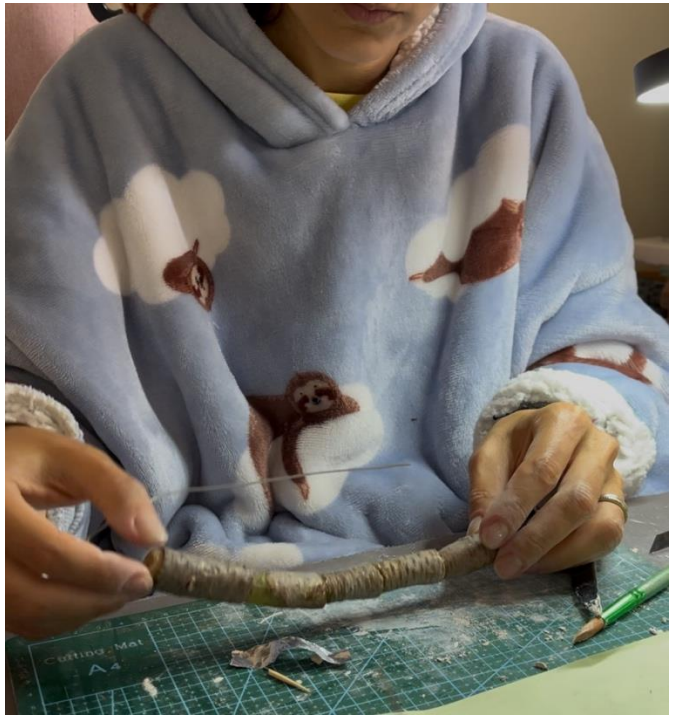


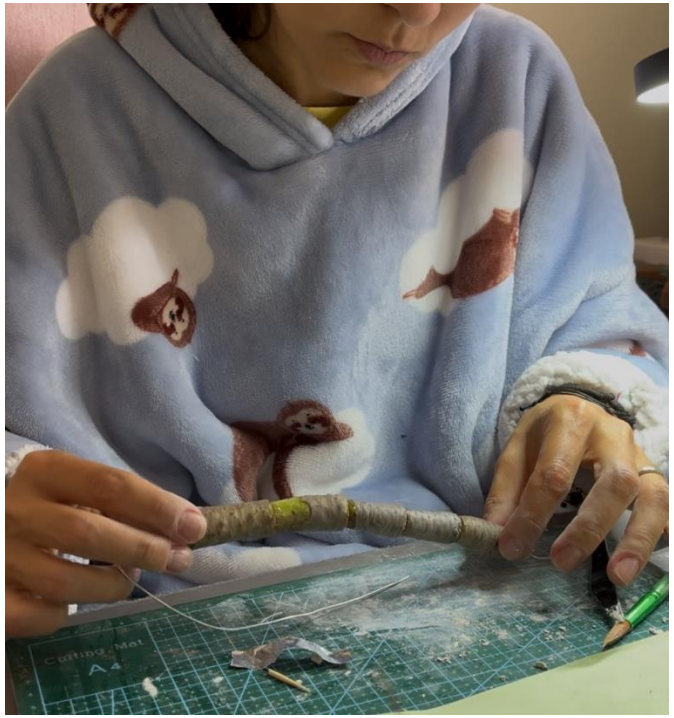
Wings





Tail





Reflective Review

Working on this project was my first experience with clay as a sculptural medium. Although I was enthusiastic to explore a new material, the process presented several unexpected challenges that shaped my learning experience.

One of the first difficulties arose during the construction of the base. In hindsight, I likely began incorrectly, which caused structural instability throughout the build. The most problematic result was that the head remained poorly connected to the body. This disconnection caused constant worry, as the piece felt fragile and vulnerable to collapse. I had to work cautiously around this weak point, which slowed my progress and forced me to adjust my techniques.

As the clay dried, new problems appeared. Fragile areas such as the legs became prone to cracking, reminding me that clay requires careful moisture management throughout the process. Drying unevenly created tensions within the sculpture, making it even more delicate and difficult to handle. I learned that controlling the environment — and working efficiently before drying set in — is critical when sculpting fragile forms.

To make the structure more sustainable, I incorporated wire to support key parts of the sculpture. Using wire helped to reinforce delicate areas, particularly where clay alone would have been too weak. This internal support was especially important as the piece grew heavier during construction.

The tail presented another distinct challenge. Rather than sculpting it from clay, I used a real branch from a succulent plant. This material had a woody texture, which visually fit the sculpture's theme but introduced practical difficulties. The branch was heavier and less flexible than expected, making attachment tricky without stressing the clay body. Aligning and balancing the tail correctly required patience and careful positioning.

Reflective Review

In addition to the clay and wood, I created wings using satin ribbon. Incorporating fabric onto the structure proved to be unexpectedly challenging. The satin ribbon was slippery and difficult to secure, requiring delicate manipulation to ensure that the wings appeared light and natural without destabilizing the sculpture.

Another unexpected issue was the overall weight. As more elements were added, including the branch and the wings, the sculpture became significantly heavier. Moving it safely during construction became a challenge, forcing me to plan each step more carefully and constantly support the piece as I worked.

Despite these difficulties, the project was incredibly valuable. I gained a strong appreciation for clay as a dynamic, living material that demands adaptability and planning. If I were to repeat the project, I would focus more on building a stronger core structure from the start and continue to use wire strategically for internal support. I would also explore better methods for combining different materials such as wood and fabric. Overall, the experience was challenging but rewarding, strengthening both my technical skills and my creative problem-solving abilities.

Conclusion

This project offered a valuable introduction to working with clay and mixed materials. Despite the many challenges—from structural instability to integrating wood, wire, and satin ribbon—the experience taught me important lessons about planning, material behavior, and creative problem-solving. It deepened my understanding of sculptural techniques and encouraged me to approach future projects with greater patience, preparation, and adaptability.